

Module 6 — The Urban Flow & The Shield

Module purpose

Modern homes and streets are noisy, busy, and full of triggers.

This module helps the owner manage public stress, street hazards, window barking, and early alone-time difficulty without pushing the dog into overwhelm.

This is not advanced reactivity or separation-anxiety treatment.

This is practical management, safer exposure, environmental shielding, and knowing when trainer or vet support is needed.

What the owner should be able to do after this module

By the end of Module 6, the owner should be able to:

1. Notice when the street is too much for the dog.
 2. Make walks shorter, calmer, and safer.
 3. Reduce access to street hazards and scavenging risks.
 4. Use distance, barriers, and timing to prevent repeated public stress.
 5. Understand why window barking can become a repeated habit.
 6. Change the home environment to reduce visual and sound triggers.
 7. Start early alone-time routines without punishing distress.
 8. Know when barking, panic, reactivity, or alone-time distress needs professional help.
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Lesson 1 — Public Stress: Make the Walk Smaller

Scenario

You take your dog outside.

A truck passes. A skateboard rolls by. A child runs past. A person in high-vis clothing appears. Another dog barks behind a fence.

Your dog starts pulling, freezing, barking, jumping, spinning, panting, or trying to rush home.

You planned a normal walk, but the dog is no longer moving calmly.

What the owner needs to notice

A walk is not automatically relaxing.

For some dogs, the street is a lot of information at once:

- traffic
- bikes
- scooters
- prams
- strangers
- children
- other dogs
- bins
- delivery drivers
- construction noise
- birds or possums
- food scraps
- smells
- narrow footpaths
- unpredictable movement

The owner needs to notice when the walk has stopped being useful and has become too difficult.

Common mistake

Thinking the dog needs a longer walk when the dog actually needs an easier walk.

Another mistake is continuing forward because the owner feels embarrassed.

Examples:

- dragging the dog past the scary thing
- staying close to triggers
- letting the dog rehearse barking or lunging
- correcting the dog without changing the environment
- choosing busy routes before the dog is ready
- expecting the dog to focus while over threshold

Better decision rule

A useful walk is one the dog can recover from.

Ask:

Is my dog still able to think, sniff, take food, and move normally?

If not, make the walk smaller.

What to do now

Use the smaller-walk reset.

Instead of forcing a full route, choose one:

- walk at a quieter time
- walk a shorter route
- cross the road early
- turn around before the trigger gets close
- use a wider footpath
- stand behind a parked car, tree, wall, or driveway opening
- give the dog sniffing time
- stop before the dog becomes frantic
- use the front yard, driveway, hallway, or car park as a mini-exposure area

The goal is not distance covered.

The goal is a dog who can notice the world and recover.

Watch for this

The walk may be too hard if the dog:

- scans constantly
- pants when not hot
- pulls without checking in
- refuses food they normally like
- freezes
- lunges
- barks repeatedly
- tries to flee
- cannot sniff
- cannot settle after returning home

The walk is more appropriate if the dog:

- sniffs
- takes food
- looks and looks away
- recovers after a sound
- can turn with the owner
- has loose body movement
- settles after the outing

When education is not enough

Seek trainer support if:

- barking, lunging, freezing, or panic repeats on walks
- the dog cannot recover with distance
- other dogs, people, children, bikes, or traffic trigger strong reactions
- the owner cannot safely manage the lead
- the dog has snapped, bitten, redirected onto the lead or owner, or escaped
- the dog's world is shrinking because walks feel unsafe

Seek vet advice if:

- public stress appears suddenly
- the dog seems painful, unwell, unusually tired, disoriented, or sensitive to movement
- the dog reacts strongly to sounds after a health change
- mobility, appetite, toileting, sleep, or energy has changed

Trainer-readiness note

Before asking for help, record:

- route
 - time of day
 - trigger
 - distance from trigger
 - first body signal
 - final reaction
 - whether the dog could eat
 - whether the dog could sniff
 - whether distance helped
 - recovery time after the walk
 - equipment used
 - whether the owner could safely manage the situation
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Lesson 2 — Street Hazards: The Shield

Scenario

Your dog grabs something from the ground.

It might be food scraps, bones, gum, bait, rubbish, animal faeces, a dead bird, a discarded vape, medication, glass, or an unknown object.

You panic and try to pull it from the mouth.

The dog clamps down, runs away, swallows, or starts guarding the item.

What the owner needs to notice

The street contains hazards the dog does not understand.

A dog may investigate with their nose and mouth before the owner has time to react.

Risk increases when:

- the dog is hungry
- the dog is overstimulated

- the lead is too loose near rubbish
- the owner is distracted
- bins are overflowing
- food shops are nearby
- parks have picnic scraps
- the dog has practised scavenging before
- the dog is walked in the same high-risk area repeatedly

The owner's job is to shield the dog from access before the dog makes a dangerous choice.

Common mistake

Reacting only after the dog has the object.

Examples:

- chasing the dog
- shouting
- prying the mouth open
- repeatedly saying "leave it" when the dog has not learned it
- walking through high-risk rubbish areas
- assuming the dog will ignore food because they ate at home
- giving too much lead near hazards

These reactions can make swallowing, running away, or guarding more likely.

Better decision rule

Prevent access before the mouth gets there.

Ask:

What is the hazard before my dog reaches it?

The owner should scan ahead, not only react behind.

What to do now

Use the shield pattern.

1. Scan five to ten steps ahead.
2. Shorten the lead before hazard zones.
3. Move the dog to the safe side of the footpath.
4. Cross the road or arc around rubbish if needed.
5. Reward the dog for looking away from the item.
6. Use a cheerful swap if the dog has a safe but unwanted item.
7. Contact a vet or poison service if the item may be toxic, sharp, dangerous, or unknown.

For known scavengers, avoid high-risk walking areas while building safer habits with trainer guidance.

Watch for this

Track hazard patterns:

- same street corner
- same park area
- near schools
- near takeaway shops
- bin night
- picnic areas
- building sites
- dog parks
- garden beds
- train stations or tram stops

Also track dog patterns:

- fast sniffing
- sudden head dip
- grabbing and moving away
- swallowing quickly
- stiffening over items
- growling when approached
- refusing to swap

When education is not enough

Contact a vet or Animal Poisons Helpline immediately if the dog may have eaten:

- bait
- unknown medication
- chocolate
- grapes or raisins
- xylitol or sugar-free products
- sharp objects
- cooked bones
- mouldy food
- toxic plants
- chemicals
- anything unknown that causes concern

Seek trainer support if:

- scavenging is repeated
- the dog guards found items
- the dog runs away with items
- the owner cannot safely manage public walks
- the dog is unsafe around rubbish, food, or dropped objects

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Tell the vet:

- suspected item
- amount
- time
- location
- dog's weight
- symptoms
- photo of object or packaging if available

Tell the trainer:

- where scavenging happens
 - what the dog grabs
 - lead length and route
 - whether the dog swaps
 - whether guarding occurs
 - what management has already been tried
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Lesson 3 — Window Barking: Build the Shield

Scenario

Your dog rushes to the window every time someone walks past.

They bark at neighbours, delivery drivers, school children, dogs, bikes, possums, cats, or cars.

The owner keeps saying:

“Stop barking.”

The barking keeps happening.

What the owner needs to notice

Window barking is often a repeated pattern.

The dog sees or hears something outside.

They bark.

The person, dog, car, or bike eventually moves away.

From the dog's point of view, barking may seem like it worked.

The dog may also be startled, frustrated, territorial, bored, overtired, or anxious.

The first question is not:

How do I stop the bark?

The better question is:

Why does my dog keep getting access to this trigger?

Common mistake

Letting the dog practise the same window routine every day.

Examples:

- leaving the dog at a front window all day
- allowing fence running
- yelling from across the room
- opening the door during barking
- letting the dog rush from window to window
- assuming the dog will get used to it through repetition
- only reacting after the barking starts

Better decision rule

Block rehearsal before training harder.

Ask:

Can I reduce what my dog can see, hear, or practise?

If the trigger stays available all day, the habit gets stronger.

What to do now

Create a shield.

Try:

- closing blinds during peak trigger times
- using frosted window film
- moving furniture away from front windows
- blocking access to the front room
- using baby gates
- using background sound to soften outside noise
- giving the dog a rest area away from the window
- offering food puzzles or chews during known trigger times
- bringing the dog inside from fence lines during busy times
- rewarding quiet moments before barking starts

Do not wait until the dog is already at full volume.

The shield works best before the trigger appears.

Watch for this

Track:

- time of barking
- location
- trigger
- window, fence, door, or balcony
- whether the dog can see the trigger
- whether the dog can hear the trigger
- how long barking lasts
- whether blocking the view helps
- whether background sound helps
- whether the dog can settle elsewhere

When education is not enough

Seek trainer support if:

- barking is persistent despite environmental changes
- barking escalates into lunging, snapping, or redirected biting
- the dog cannot settle away from the window
- neighbours are affected
- the owner cannot safely interrupt or redirect
- the dog reacts to many everyday sounds or sights
- the behaviour appears fear-based or highly distressed

Seek vet advice if:

- noise sensitivity appears suddenly
- the dog startles unusually
- hearing, pain, sleep, appetite, energy, or movement changes
- barking is paired with panic, trembling, pacing, drooling, or inability to recover

Trainer-readiness note

Before asking for help, record:

- trigger
 - time of day
 - window or fence location
 - whether the trigger is visual, sound-based, or both
 - what blocks the trigger
 - what does not help
 - barking duration
 - recovery time
 - whether the dog can eat or settle afterward
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Lesson 4 — Alone-Time Calm Without Punishing Distress

Scenario

You leave the room or house.

Your dog barks, cries, scratches, paces, follows, chews, toilets, drools, or waits by the door.

You are told to let the dog “cry it out.”

You are not sure whether this is normal adjustment, boredom, poor routine, or serious distress.

What the owner needs to notice

Alone-time difficulty is not spite.

A dog left alone may be:

- underprepared
- bored
- overtired
- confused by routine changes
- worried about separation
- distressed by confinement
- reacting to outside sounds
- needing toileting
- not yet comfortable in the home

The owner needs to notice whether the dog is settling or panicking.

Common mistake

Punishing the dog after returning.

Examples:

- scolding for destruction
- yelling about barking
- punishing toileting after the fact
- forcing longer absences too quickly
- using the crate while the dog is panicking
- making departures and returns highly emotional
- assuming the dog did it “on purpose”

Punishment after the event does not teach calm alone time.

Better decision rule

Practise absence below panic level.

Ask:

Can my dog stay calm for this amount of alone time?

If not, make the step smaller and safer.

What to do now

Start with tiny separations.

Examples:

- step behind a baby gate for a few seconds
- walk to another room and return calmly
- close a door briefly and reopen before panic
- sit outside the room while the dog has a chew
- leave the dog with a safe food puzzle while still nearby
- practise calm departures and calm returns

Keep absences boring and predictable.

Do:

- meet toileting needs first
- provide safe rest space
- use safe enrichment
- return before panic where possible
- record what happened
- build slowly

Do not:

- punish barking after returning
- leave the dog to panic repeatedly
- push duration just because the owner is impatient
- rely on food toys if the dog is too distressed to eat
- ignore severe distress

Watch for this

The dog is coping better if they:

- eat
- rest
- chew calmly
- move around normally

- settle after the owner leaves
- recover quickly when the owner returns

The dog may be distressed if they:

- bark or howl repeatedly
- scratch doors or windows
- pace
- drool
- tremble
- toilet only when left
- destroy exit points
- refuse food
- injure themselves
- panic as soon as departure cues appear

When education is not enough

Seek trainer or veterinary behaviour support if:

- the dog panics when alone
- the dog injures themselves or damages exits
- barking, howling, pacing, drooling, toileting, or destruction is repeated
- the dog cannot eat when left
- the dog becomes distressed before the owner leaves
- progress stalls or worsens
- the owner must leave for longer than the dog can handle

Seek vet advice if:

- toileting, vomiting, drooling, lethargy, pain, confusion, or sudden behaviour change may be medical
- the dog is older and the behaviour is new
- the dog is injuring themselves
- medication or veterinary behaviour referral may be needed

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Record one short video if safe and practical.

Bring notes on:

- how long after departure distress starts
- what the dog does first
- barking, howling, pacing, drooling, scratching, chewing, toileting, or escape attempts
- whether food is eaten
- whether the dog settles
- recovery time after return
- confinement setup
- daily routine
- exercise/rest before departure

- whether behaviour is new or long-standing
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Tool 1 — Street Hazard Rules

Use this before and during walks.

Before the walk

- ☐ Dog has toileted if needed
- ☐ Lead/harness/collar fit is checked
- ☐ Rewards are ready
- ☐ Route is chosen for the dog's current ability
- ☐ High-risk rubbish/food areas are avoided where possible
- ☐ Owner knows the emergency vet/poison plan

During the walk

- ☐ Scan ahead
- ☐ Keep dog away from rubbish
- ☐ Shorten lead near hazards
- ☐ Cross or turn before the dog reaches unsafe items
- ☐ Reward looking away from ground hazards
- ☐ Do not chase if the dog grabs something
- ☐ Swap if safe
- ☐ Call vet/poison advice if ingestion may be dangerous

After the walk

- ☐ Record hazards found
 - ☐ Record triggers
 - ☐ Record whether the route was too hard
 - ☐ Choose an easier route next time if needed
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Tool 2 — Urban Trigger Log

Use this for street stress, public fear, barking, pulling, freezing, or lunging.

| Date/time | Location | Trigger | Distance | First signal | Final reaction | Dog could eat? | Recovery
time | Next adjustment | |---|---|---|---|---|---|---|

Review after three entries

Ask:

- Which trigger appears most often?

- How close is too close?
- Does crossing the road help?
- Does a quieter time help?
- Does the dog recover after the walk?
- Is the reaction improving, unchanged, or worsening?
- Is trainer support needed?

Tool 3 — Window Barking Environment Checklist

Use this before correcting the dog.

Trigger access

- ☐ Dog can see the footpath
- ☐ Dog can see the street
- ☐ Dog can see neighbours
- ☐ Dog can see dogs passing
- ☐ Dog can access a fence line
- ☐ Dog can hear repeated outdoor sounds
- ☐ Dog has a clear daily barking pattern

Shield options

- ☐ Close blinds
- ☐ Use frosted window film
- ☐ Move furniture away from window
- ☐ Block room access during trigger times
- ☐ Use baby gate
- ☐ Bring dog inside from fence
- ☐ Use background sound
- ☐ Provide rest zone away from trigger
- ☐ Offer enrichment before trigger time
- ☐ Reward quiet moments before barking starts

Track

Time	Trigger	Visual/sound/both	Shield used	Barking duration	Recovery
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Tool 4 — Alone-Time Snapshot

Use this before deciding the dog is “just being naughty.”

Before leaving

- ☐ Dog has toileted
- ☐ Dog has had appropriate activity
- ☐ Dog has had rest
- ☐ Safe area is prepared
- ☐ Food puzzle or chew is safe and available
- ☐ Departure is calm
- ☐ Absence is short enough for current ability

During absence

If using video or audio, record:

- ☐ barking/howling
- ☐ pacing
- ☐ drooling
- ☐ trembling
- ☐ scratching doors/windows
- ☐ chewing exit points
- ☐ toileting
- ☐ refusing food
- ☐ settling
- ☐ sleeping

After return

- ☐ Return is calm
- ☐ Dog recovers quickly
- ☐ Dog remains frantic
- ☐ Damage occurred
- ☐ Toileting occurred
- ☐ Next absence should be shorter
- ☐ Professional support may be needed

Module completion action

The owner can complete Module 6 when they can confirm:

- ☐ They know how to make walks smaller when the dog is stressed
- ☐ They can identify at least three public triggers
- ☐ They can scan for street hazards before the dog reaches them
- ☐ They have a plan for dangerous ingestion
- ☐ They have reduced at least one window or fence trigger
- ☐ They understand barking may signal stress, boredom, frustration, alerting, or distress
- ☐ They know not to punish alone-time distress after returning
- ☐ They can record alone-time behaviour clearly
- ☐ They know when trainer or vet support is needed

Module 6 dashboard summary

Current focus

Protect the dog from repeated overwhelm in real-world environments.

Today's action

Choose one shield: easier walk route, blocked window view, safer street path, or shorter alone-time practice.

Capability gained

Public environment handling.

Decision rule

Make the environment easier before asking for better behaviour.

Escalation reminder

Repeated panic, lunging, snapping, biting, escape attempts, dangerous scavenging, severe barking, inability to recover, self-injury, or sudden behaviour change needs professional support.

Trainer-readiness output

If problems continue, the owner should be able to describe:

- trigger
- distance
- first body signal
- final reaction
- recovery time
- route or home setup
- what was shielded or blocked
- what was still too hard
- whether the dog could eat or settle
- whether a vet concern exists
- what has already been tried

Internal source map

This section is for repo/source control only. It should not appear inside the learner flow.

Core source base

Module 6 should be supported by a source-quality pass before publication because the earlier Gemini scan used weak sources for window barking and alone-time calm. That scan is retained only as an idea pool.

For barking, use source material only to support broad owner-level claims: barking may reflect an underlying trigger such as pain, fear, boredom, frustration, separation-related distress, or territorial/alerting behaviour; different barking causes need different responses; and positive, trigger-aware approaches are preferred over punishment. Current available source support is acceptable for internal drafting but should be replaced with direct RSPCA/AVA/AVSAB/AVMA pages where possible before public-source documentation is finalised.

For alone-time distress, use only conservative wording: barking, howling, pacing, drooling, trembling, toileting, destruction, exit-point damage, refusal of food, and self-injury can indicate significant separation-related distress and should not be treated as spite or disobedience. Current source support is suitable for internal drafting but should be upgraded to direct veterinary-behaviour or welfare pages before publication.

For noise-related stress, use owner-level signs only: hiding, panting, pacing, digging, drooling, barking, trembling, attempts to escape, and toileting may occur with noise fear or anxiety. Do not convert this into diagnosis or treatment advice.

For reward-based and non-aversive handling of public stress, window barking, and alone-time distress, AVSAB's humane-training position should remain the preferred Tier 2 authority: avoid force, pain, fear, intimidation, and discomfort-based methods; teach replacement behaviours and manage the environment instead of punishing distress.

Claims requiring careful wording

Public stress

Approved wording:

If the dog cannot recover, make the walk easier.

Avoid:

Force the dog through the walk until they get used to it.

Street hazards

Approved wording:

Scan ahead and prevent access before the dog reaches unsafe items.

Avoid:

Just tell the dog to leave it after they already have the item.

Window barking

Approved wording:

Reduce visual and sound triggers before the barking starts.

Avoid:

Yell until the dog stops barking.

Alone-time calm

Approved wording:

Practise absence below panic level and seek support if distress is repeated or severe.

Avoid:

Let the dog cry it out.

Separation distress

Approved wording:

Repeated panic when left alone may need trainer, veterinary, or veterinary-behaviour support.

Avoid:

This module treats separation anxiety.

Trainer-level protocols

Approved wording:

Track triggers, reduce exposure, make the setup easier, and seek professional support when needed.

Avoid:

Prescribing desensitisation/counter-conditioning plans, decibel thresholds, long treatment timelines, or technical reactivity protocols.

Codex implementation note

Store this as:

```text id="m8otfv" /docs/education/curriculum/06-the-urban-flow-and-the-shield.md

Optional supporting files:

```
```text id="bscsxg"  
/docs/education/tools/street-hazard-rules.md  
/docs/education/tools/urban-trigger-log.md  
/docs/education/tools/window-barking-environment-checklist.md  
/docs/education/tools/alone-time-snapshot.md  
/docs/education/research/module-6-the-urban-flow-and-the-shield-source-map.md
```